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Fluid New World (1969–1972)

> *The obvious focus of our efforts must be to convince Nixon that apprehensions felt in the United States regarding growth of Communist influence in Asia, whether of [the] Soviet or of [the] Chinese variety, can be dealt with effectively only by strengthening or stabilizing forces in Asia, which, they must see, inevitably depends on the stabilizing influence of India.*
>
> —P. N. Haksar, Prime Minister Indira Gandhi's office, 1969[1]

> *Imagine our feelings. The original misunderstanding with the United States had arisen because of our contacts with China, the Soviet Union and Eastern Europe. We find it difficult to understand why, when the US policy toward these countries changed, the resentment against us increased.*
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> —Indira Gandhi, prime minister of India, 1972[2]

On December 9, 1971, at a meeting to discuss the ongoing India-Pakistan war, President Richard Nixon and National Security Adviser Henry Kissinger discussed sending an aircraft carrier to the Bay of Bengal. Kissinger recommended "mov[ing] the carrier so that we can tell the Chinese tomorrow to move their forces to the frontier."[3] The administration subsequently deployed the USS *Enterprise*, ostensibly to deter Delhi and demonstrate to Beijing that it was willing to oppose India. This was a far cry from 1962, when the US had contemplated deploying an aircraft carrier